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[Introduction](#)

You should only try to preside if you have a good handle on parliamentary procedure.

When running for PO, simply state your name, credentials, and your desire to run things effectively. Sample PO speeches are at the end of this guide for your reference. You have three important jobs as presiding officer:

1. Keep time.

The most important job of the PO is to give correct gavel signals to the speaker. Do not underestimate this responsibility! Everybody, especially the speaker, will notice if you forget to give a signal. You will be completely dropped by the parli. You may time with your phone if it is on airplane mode and you tell the parli you are doing so. One tap at 2:00, two at 2:30, three at 2:55. If you're late on a signal, move the next signal back a few seconds to even it and give a few extra seconds. You must read the time of the speech after the speech.

"Speech time: Two minutes & 55 seconds"

2. Keep recency.

You need to keep full precedence and recency for speakers and precedence for questions. Precedence is the number of times somebody spoke and recency is the order.

To keep track of questioners, make a seating chart of the room. Organize the seating chart so it is viewed from the front of the room. Write everybody's name in a box. Every time a person asks a question, make a tally mark in their box. Call on the people with fewer questions (AKA fewer tallies).

To keep track of speakers, draw a few columns on a piece of paper. Write the speaker's speech order,

speech type (affirmation/negation) and last name when they speak.

Note: You must keep 100% accurate precedence and recency for speakers. You will be corrected if you make an error. A good tip is to make note of who wants to speak on one side, then figure out who has the best recency during the speech. Just make sure to give time signals!

I recommend consulting the parliamentarian if you need to keep both precedence and recency for questioning. You will need to keep precedence for sure, but recency is usually up in the air. If it is your first time presiding, let the parliamentarian and the chamber know and ask if you can only keep precedence if that makes you more comfortable.

3. Keep control.

There's a reason you PO with a gavel. Your final job is to maintain decorum even if you have to gavel everybody into silence. You must ensure that nobody speaks out of turn and that things don't become chaotic. Do not hesitate to rule things out of order if they are inappropriate. You must speak clearly, loudly, and with confidence when you PO. Remember that you control the chamber and do not be afraid to use that gavel.

As the PO, you are free to develop your own conventions, so long as you fall within general guidelines.

Order of Procedure

1. If you give a candidacy speech, state that you'll be fair and work to make sure time is best spent giving speeches.

2. After you are elected, give your PO speech and then say "this chamber will come to order."

a. **Note: There are sample speeches at the end.**

b. Note: Always stand when addressing the chamber (to project authority). Use a calm, controlled and caring voice to show a genuine interest in the chamber's business. Additionally, at the beginning of the session, remind members to stand and seek recognition when they wish to move. Some schools have those desks where the chairs and desks are connected. Make an exception for that. Ask the chamber what they feel would be best. Do not call for motions; rather, pause briefly between speeches. Note: Saying "barring all motions" is the same as calling for motions, but in reverse.

3. When you are ready to begin, ask the parliamentarian to read the first bill on the agenda. "Mr. Parliamentarian, would you like to read the relevant clauses or would you like to forgo the reading". Afterwards, ask the chamber "Is there an author present?" If there is no author, ask "Is there a sponsor present?" Be sure to familiarize yourself with the tournament rules as different tournaments differ when it comes to sponsorships and authorships; some tournaments require there be a sponsor if there is no author, some tournaments allow you to call a first affirmative if no one is willing to sponsor the legislation.

a. Note: When you recognize speakers, use the third person: "The chair recognizes..."

4. When a speaker concludes, say "That speech was __minutes and __seconds; questioners, please rise." Call on one legislator at a time, until the questioning period is over. You should keep track of questions to allow a fair distribution.

a. Note: Be sure to familiarize yourself with the questioning rules of the tournament you are presiding.

WACFL only has questioning time after the first affirmative speech (sponsorship/authorship). Additionally, some tournaments allow you to use the time left over from a speech for questioning (like WACFLs) while others don't (like Nationals); for example, if the speech time is 2:35, 25 seconds of questioning would occur for some tournaments.

5. You may gesture for questioners to sit down when it is apparent that time is running out. Afterwards, say: "The questioning period has concluded, and the speaker may be seated." If there is no questioning time due to tournament rules following a speech, make sure to always say "The speaker may be seated".

6. Then say: "Negation speakers, please rise." Call on a speaker, using recency and balancing areas of the room as much as possible. After the speech, say "That speech was _ minutes and _ seconds; questioners, please rise."

7. When you have called on the last person who wishes to speak on a bill/resolution, say: "Since this is the last senator/representative who wishes to speak on this issue, if no one objects following his/her speech, we will immediately move to previous question following his/her speech." (That way, a separate vote to call previous question is unnecessary).

8. When it's time to debate the next legislation, say "The next item of business is —" (say the legislation's title).

Procedural Notes

1. If you call for a negation or affirmative speech and no one rises to speak, say "The chair highly frowns upon a one-sided debate, but the debate must go on" and continue to call for the opposite side. However, if the debate gets very one-sided, assert your authority as chair and move to previous question by saying "If there is no objection, I hereby move to previous question as the debate has become very one-sided." Assuming no objection, move directly into voting procedures. If there is an objection, take a voice vote on the motion before moving on to voting procedures.
2. There must always be a first affirmative speech - you cannot move onto a negation if no one is willing to sponsor or be the first affirmative.
3. Don't be afraid to call motions (and competitors) out of order. Motions that needlessly waste time should be ruled dilatory or out of order. Competitors who are whispering, being a distraction, or acting unsportsmanship-like should be called out of order and be asked to correct their behavior.
4. Above all, have power and confidence as presiding officer! You are in charge of the chamber, and confidence goes a long way in keeping decorum and helping your PO score.
5. Technically speaking, if somebody moves to extend questioning longer than somebody else or recess longer than someone else, that longer motion does not take precedence over the shorter motion since a motion cannot take precedence over itself. Just know this; nobody else will ever point it out.
6. Once a motion has been seconded, it can still be withdrawn and or amended by the author. A motion becomes property of the chamber once the chair states the motion or any debate/action is taken on the motion.
7. Lay on the Table had a higher precedence than Previous Question. It was created so a chamber could temporarily put aside a motion, with the intent of coming back to it. Once debate is finished on a topic, the previous question should be moved. Lay on the Table should only be moved when the chamber wishes to come back to it.
8. Once the chamber goes through three consecutive speeches on the same side, the chamber DOES NOT automatically move the previous question. The chamber should if debate becomes one-sided, but it is not required.
9. Orders of the Day are not called at the end of a session. An Orders of the Day is a particular item of business set in advance to be taken up. They are called up by the chair when moving to another bill or resolution on the

agenda, there is no motion to call for Orders of the Day. An agenda, by definition, is a collection of orders of the day, every time you start debate on another topic, an order of the day is called up.

To know what motions take precedence over other motions, reference the image on the right: whichever motion is higher on the list has higher precedence.

Example: If someone motions to previous question and then someone else motions to table the topic BEFORE a second is made on the first motion, the tabling motion takes precedence since it's higher on the official List of Motions and that is the motion that is voted on.

10. At the end of the day, if you are POing the last session of the day, say: "I now move to Orders of the Day". This means we vote on the legislation and then you thank the chamber for an amazing session, and say: "Without further ado, we are adjourned" (Bang gavel).

11. When you tell someone to have a seat, no more motions can be made to the speaker like extending questioning.

12. After a motion is made and a SECOND has been voiced, no one can call another motion because we are in voting procedure for the motion (even if the second motion has higher precedence).

TABLE OF PARLIAMENTARY MOTIONS

Following is the National Speech & Debate Association motion chart, annotated (non-shaded) to show motions used most often.

Table of Most Frequently Used Parliamentary Motions Adapted for use in National Speech & Debate Association Congressional Debate			Second Required?	Debatable?	Amendable?	Required Vote	May Interrupt?
Privileged	24. Fix time for reassembling	To arrange time of next meeting	Yes	Yes-T	Yes-T	Majority	Yes
	23. Adjourn	To dismiss the meeting	Yes	No	Yes-T	Majority	No
	22. Recess	To dismiss the meeting for a specific length of time	Yes	Yes	Yes-T	Majority	No
	21. Rise to a question of privilege	To make a personal request during debate	No	No	No	Decision of the Chair	Yes
	20. Call for orders of the day	To force consideration of a postponed motion	No	No	No	Decision of the Chair	Yes
Incidental	19. Appeal a decision of the chair	To reverse a decision	Yes	No	No	Majority	Yes
	18. Rise to a point of order or parliamentary procedure	To correct a parliamentary error or ask a question	No	No	No	Decision of the Chair	Yes
	17. Division of the chamber	To verify a voice vote	No	No	No	Decision of the Chair	Yes
	16. Object to the consideration of a question	To suppress action	No	No	No	2/3	Yes
	15. Divide a motion	To consider its parts separately	Yes	No	Yes	Majority	No
Subsidiary	14. Leave to modify or withdraw a motion	To modify or withdraw a motion	No	No	No	Majority	No
	13. Suspend the rules	To take action contrary to standing rules	Yes	No	No	2/3	No
	12. Rescind	To repeal previous action	Yes	Yes	Yes	2/3	No
	11. Reconsider	To consider a defeated motion again	Yes	Yes	No	Majority	No
	10. Take from the table	To consider tabled motion	Yes	No	No	Majority	No
Main	9. Lay on the table	To defer action	Yes	No	No	Majority	No
	8. Previous question	To force an immediate vote	Yes	No	No	2/3	No
	7. Limit or extend debate	To modify freedom of debate	Yes	Yes	Yes-T	2/3	No
	6. Postpone to a certain time	To defer action	Yes	Yes	Yes	Majority	Yes
	5. Refer to a committee *	For further study	Yes	Yes	Yes	Majority	Yes
	4. Amend an amendment *	To modify an amendment	1/3	Yes	No	Majority	No
	3. Amend *	To modify a motion	1/3	Yes	Yes	Majority	No
	2. Postpone indefinitely	To suppress action	Yes	Yes	No	Majority	No
	1. Main motion	To introduce a business	Yes	Yes	Yes	Majority	No

How to Handle Motions

When a motion occurs do the following:

-Say "Senator _____, state your motion" and the person will read their motion

-If the motion is inappropriate such as unnecessary additional questioning, say: "I'm going to rule that dilatory because _____." As you become more experienced you will get a sense of when to rule things dilatory.

-If the motion is in order, say: "Is there a second?"

-If there is no second, say: "There is no second, the motion fails."

-If there is a second, say: "All in favor say aye." wait for the ayes "All against say nay." wait for the nays

-If one side obviously has it, then say: "The ayes/nays do have it, the motion passes/fails"

-If the vote is uncertain, such as when you need a 2/3 majority, then say: "The chair now calls for a division of the house."

-Have people stand for in favor and against; count them

-Note: anybody may call for a division of the house and you should respect their call unless the vote is obvious

-Say, "on a vote of ___ ayes to ___ nays, the motion passes/fails"

-If the motion passes, bang your gavel

That clearly meets the 2/3 majority requirement. Now we will move into 30 seconds of questioning. Questioners,

please rise

The chair is going to end the recess early and call this session back into order

After Previous Question Motion Passes:

- Motion to previous question passes and you bang the gavel
- You say: "We are now in voting procedures"
- Say: "All those in favor of passing this legislation please stand and sit when I point to you"
- Count the people
- Say: "All against please stand and sit when I point to you"
- Count the people
- Say: "All abstaining please stand and sit when I point to you"
- Count the people
- Say: "On a vote of _ ayes to _ nays to _ abstentions, the legislation passes/fails" (**put vote count on board if possible**)
- If you need to break the tie of ayes and nays, you should break the tie and briefly explain why you voted the way you did
- Note: If the count on the board doesn't add up to the amount of competitors (excluding you), you must do a recount.

After Table Topic Motion Passes:

- Motion to table the topic passes and you bang the gavel
 - Say: "We will now move on to debate the next bill".
- Someone can motion to untable a topic. This is the same procedure as the tabling a topic but can only be done after/before debating a bill (so not in the middle of debating topic).

Other types of Parliamentary Procedures:

When someone makes one of the following non-motions, they should be recognized before they explain further. Make sure to keep decorum and correct competitors if they do not wait for you to recognize them before they continue to explain their non-motion.

- A competitor will say "I rise to a point of personal privilege" or "I rise to a point of order" or "I rise to a point of inquiry"
- Recognize the competitor by responding with: "State that" and wait for them to explain, then respond accordingly:
- For **points of personal privilege**, say: "Granted" or "Not Granted because..."
- For **points of order**, admit that you made a mistake or correct the competitor and explain why you didn't make a mistake
- For **points of inquiry**, answer their questions appropriately and ask the parliamentarian if you don't know the answer

Finer Points on Presiding and Parliamentary Procedure

Reintroduce Legislation:

A rare motion is a motion to reintroduce legislation. You'll see this motion only on the local level and nobody ever has any idea what it is. It's something that you should know so that you can propose to execute it while presiding and sometimes save the day for a novice. Let's look at an example:

Suppose that at a WACFL, complete novice Tim has only prepped two pieces of legislation. One of those legislation was debated during the first session and Tim stood every time to give a speech but wasn't chosen. Then suppose somebody moves to previous question and Tim, not knowing what that means, fails to speak up. Then the chamber moves on to new debate and Tim doesn't know what to do.

There is recourse for Tim and as a good final session PO, you need to know what to do to help piddling novices like Tim

give their speech. You can lead the chamber through a motion to reintroduce. If there is sufficient time at the end of the 4th session, this is a worthwhile activity.

Somebody who voted on the prevailing side of the legislation needs to motion to reintroduce the legislation for reconsideration. This motion necessitates a second by any member in round and takes a $\frac{2}{3}$ majority to pass. You then pick up debate right where you left off. When Tim finishes giving his one speech you need to move to table or previous question the legislation again.

Most parlis will be both impressed by your grasp of parliamentary procedure and kindness toward Tim. Tim will be happy and not quit Congress. You get to be a good person. Yay for everybody.

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Tips & Things to Look Out For (+ONLINE DEBATE)

Spend the time to thoroughly go over your procedures in your PO speech. This is your only chance to speak extensively. Do not rush because you need to leave an impression. Write out the points you want to make in your speech so you leave nothing out.

- Open the floor for debate yourself. The motion to open the floor for debate does not exist. Bang the gavel to signal the opening of the floor for debate.
- When people make motions or points of personal privilege, ask them to stand. Note that you do not motion to a point of personal privilege to exit the chamber. You simply rise to a point of personal privilege. Correct people on this common error.
- Memorize the recency chart during break after the first legislation is debated. Doing this makes things go a lot faster.
- Bang the gavel for decorum if people start to speak out of turn. If things get hectic prompt the chamber to take a brief in house recess.
- Bang the gavel whenever a motion passes. It's appropriate and gives you authority.
- When you adjourn, congratulate all of the competitors, thank the judges and parli, and say that you call the session to adjourn. Bang you gavel once when you adjourn.

- **ONLINE DEBATE NOTES**

- o Make sure to establish protocols for technical difficulties in your opening PO speech. This is not only helpful for you & your chamber to know in advance, but it gives you brownie points with the judges because not everyone does this and it indicates that you are well-prepared!
 - Example: "If a speaker cuts out and its for less than 10 sec, I (as the PO) will just keep going and let the speaker finish. If the audio cuts out for more than 10 sec, I will defer to the parliamentarian and we can restart if necessary. I also request that if you notice any lag when the speaker is speaking, please turn off your video to help with connection, as long as the parliamentarian and judges are ok with that."
- o Have an online presiding chart to keep track of precedence and recency (different from in-person tracking on notepads!)

Sample PO Speeches

Good morning. I am Representative ____ from Rock Ridge High School. As such, I would like to thank you for electing me as your presiding officer. My top priority will be to run a fast, fair and efficient chamber. As such, I will not tolerate any dilatory motions or expository questions. As a reminder, a dilatory motion is a motion that is made, fails, and is made again; or a motion that needlessly wastes time. An expository question is a question that brings in outside information, has two parts, or is a statement. Both waste time and will not be tolerated. As this is an online tournament my timekeeping procedures will be a little different. I will raise a placard to notify you at 2:00 minutes, another at 2:30, and finally at 3:00 where I will give you a 10 second grace period before I will have to cut you off. Please do not abuse my grace period. For choosing speakers, I will be going off of precedence, recency, and then randomness. Precedence is the number of speeches you have given. Recency is the order in which you have spoken. . Does the parliamentarian have anything to add? Judges, would you like to introduce yourself.

I hereby call this session to order. Let's get started.

BANG GAVEL